Finger Painting in a Murphy Bed

By David L. Peterson

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

REGGIE: *(picking up a note from the counter and beginning to read it)* What's this?

MYRA: It's nothing. *(She takes the note from REG, folds it and puts it away.)* A note from Ludlow.

REGGIE: It's a strange note . . . how many has he written?

MYRA: Counting today's? One thousand eight hundred and twenty-four.

REGGIE: It's iambic pentameter. Like Shakespeare . . .

MYRA: Yeah, he's into him now. Last month it was some scrag called Dickenson. I liked them better in the early years when he'd quote Barney Rubble. Now *that* I could understand.

REGGIE: Why does he quote famous writers?

MYRA: When Ma died she had some classical books she'd collected over the years. Lud really wanted the books.

REGGIE: When did your mother pass away?

MYRA: 'Bout five years ago ...

REGGIE: One thousand, eight hundred -

MYRA: And twenty-four notes ago . . .

REGGIE: I'm sorry. Was she old when she died?

MYRA: Not particularly . . . slit her wrists . . . such a waste . . . Lud found her . . .

REGGIE: Is that why Lud is the way he is?

MYRA: Lud's the way he is 'cause it's the way he's always been. People always want

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simple, tidy little answers to the most complicated matters . . . but people . . . they're a little more complicated. I don't think you or me or anybody else on this God-given planet knows exactly what's turning around up there. Some things defy explanation . . .

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Well, that's the background . . . . at least as much as we can tell you about the chain of events that led to the current relationship between*
ACTRESS: *Myra and her younger brother, Ludlow*
ACTOR: *There's no doubt that Ludlow is special . . . call it Asperger's*
ACTRESS: *Call it a mental disability*
ACTOR: *Heck . . . I'd call him an Idiot Savant (whispers) but that's not politically correct . .*
ACTRESS: *Oh, enough of trying to explain what Ludlow is like. We'll let you see for yourself*
ACTOR: *FLASHBACK to earlier that day, in a scene from*
TOGETHER: *Finger Painting in a Murphy Bed by David L. Peterson*

(Lights up on a small cramped living room. Myra enters with groceries and heads for the kitchenette. Ludlow is out of site, under the Murphy Bed. Myra can't see him, but the audience can)

MYRA: Hey Ludlow! I'm home. Can you come in here for a sec? *(She closes the kitchen window, walks to the front door and shuts it. She returns to the groceries.)* C'mon already . . . I need to talk to you . . . about tonight *(She spies a note taped to the television. She walks over, picks up the note.)* And what do we have here? "Friends, Romans, and any other cold and unloving family relations who may find amusement at my demise. I am going to a better place. A land of chicken waste. Where I am loved as a human and not as an individual. Heretofore I may be a bit melancholy, but be that as it may, I put on clean underwear today. Do not cry. Ludlow." *(She looks around placing the note on the table.)* Ludlow!!! I gotcha Twinkies!!!

LUDLOW: *(From underneath cot.)* You're late.

MYRA: I know, I'm sorry. The G was out of wack.

LUDLOW: Subways suck.

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MYRA: Thank you Mr. Giuliani - why don't you do something about it? And don't use that word, you know I don't like that word . . . Come on out of there. *(She resumes putting away groceries.)* I thought you might be under the sink.

LUDLOW: I don't fit under the sink no more. Can I have my Twinkies now?

MYRA: Come out from under the cot first. We gotta talk.

LUDLOW: *(long pause)* I . . . can't.

MYRA: Any why is that?

LUDLOW: My zipper is stuck in the spring.

MYRA: Well, what do you suggest I do?

LUDLOW: Leave me here to die ...

MYRA: Not in my living room, champ!

LUDLOW: [Just] lift the bed up and help me to disengage.

MYRA: *(She lifts the bed up with Ludlow still pinned to it like a cat on a wall.)* Hang on, hang on. Don't squirm - Almost got it . . . there! *(LUDLOW makes a dash for the groceries.)* Hang on there buddy . . . just what in the name of Theodore D. Roosevelt were you doing all crucified on the cot springs like that?

LUDLOW: I was looking at the pee stains . . . some of them look like dogs and some like clouds and some like boats on the high seas. Well, there was this one that looked just like Aphrodite - she was a famous Roman prostitute - an she looked like she was crying, but I couldn't make it out, so I went closer and I reached out to touch her tear an -

MYRA: Yeah?

LUDLOW: Her eyeball moved.

MYRA: Get outta here:

LUDLOW: Well, it was a cockroach. No ordinary cockroach, this one had a wallet!!!

MYRA: Did you kill it?

LUDLOW: Sort of . . . you got my Twinkies?

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MYRA: What do you mean "sort of'?

LUDLOW: Well, I opened the kitchen window to let him out, and I picked up a newspaper to get him on . . . . And I snuck up to the cot, silently stalking this king of the slum beasts . . . carefully trying to edge the paper real close under him . . .

MYRA: And . . .

LUDLOW: He went right for my throat!!!

MYRA: Oh, Ludlow.

LUDLOW: He did! Honest - straight for the jugular vein. During the brief but fierce skirmish, I managed to somehow get tangled in this jagged web of springs you call a cot.

MYRA: And the roach?

LUDLOW: He shall live to see yet another day and another battle.

MYRA: Alright. That's worth a pack of Twinkies . . . here. *(She tosses him the Twinkies.)*

LUDLOW: Thanks.

MYRA: Now listen, I got something to tell you, about tonight. *(She begins to put away the rest of groceries}*

LUDLOW: Get my note? ... Perchance? Did you like it?

MYRA: What does uh - "melancholy" mean?

LUDLOW: Oh, that I got from *That Gentleman from Verona.* It's a play - by Shakespeare. He's very old.

MYRA: I see. What's it mean?

LUDLOW: I'm not sure ... I think it means you got the squirts.

MYRA: Lud!! Don't you say ~

LUDLOW: *(Cringing.)* Don't hit me - please don't hit me, Myra . . . please.

MYRA: Have I ever hit you? C'mon Lud, have I ever?

LUDLOW: No.

MYRA: Then don't say something like that . . . it hurts my feelings.

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LUDLOW: Didn't mean to.

MYRA: Eat your Twinkie. I'm glad you put on some clean underwear.

LUDLOW: Oh, you got that part.

MYRA: So what did you do today?

LUDLOW: Got stuck to a cot.

MYRA: Before that.

LUDLOW: That consumed the majority of my time.

MYRA: Alright . . . I get any messages or anything today?

LUDLOW: Mrs. Ferster came by with some laundry for you to do. Big fat cow.

MYRA: I need the work Lud, she needs to drop it off.

LUDLOW: She's the Anti-Christ.

MYRA: I thought Alex Trebec was the Anti-Christ.

LUDLOW: That was last week.

MYRA: So where is it? . . . Lud? Lud, did you not let her in?

LUDLOW: Well . . . I wasn't sure if it was her or not!!

MYRA: Lud, that's what the peephole's for. Did you look through it?

LUDLOW: Yeah, but she had the laundry packed up past her face. All I could see was her knuckles.

MYRA: Did they look like Mrs. Fester's knuckles?

LUDLOW: Yeah, but-

MYRA: Lud, c'mon!! I need the extra money. You can't keep doin' this to me . . . *(Softer.)* Okay?

LUDLOW: I'm sorry . . . it was a very big cockroach.

MYRA: I'm sure . . . any other messages?

LUDLOW: Somebody dropped a note off for you.

MYRA: Where is it? *(Ludlow digs it out of his back pocket and holds it up for Myra; she opens note and smiles.)* Myra, you lucky dog . . . he's a charmer all right.

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LUDLOW: Who's Reggie?

MYRA: Why did you read my note?

LUDLOW: I didn't.

MYRA: Then how did you know it was from Reginald?

LUDLOW: Doesn't . . . it say "Reggie" on the note?

MYRA: *Lud!!* Did you read my note?

LUDLOW: No!! I didn't!! . . . sort of . . . *(Heading for the adjacent room.)* I'm gonna take a nap.

MYRA: Just hold it there Mister. Come back here . . . now . . . . *(Ludlow returns, contrite)*

MYRA: Do you know what you did wrong?

LUDLOW: Yes.

MYRA: Alright . . . want to paint me a picture? How 'bout it?

LUDLOW: Okay. *(He goes to drawer, takes out his supplies.)*

MYRA: *(Going back to her groceries.)* I want no more "sunburst yellow" on the floor. It looks like we got a sick pet when it stains the carpet. *(long beat while each work)* . . . What'cha paintin' me?

LUDLOW: Puck.

MYRA: You painting me a hockey puck?

LUDLOW: *Puck, Puck, Puck.* Servant to Oberon - King of the fairies!!!

MYRA: Oh. That's okay then . . .

LUDLOW: What's he look like?

MYRA: The king of the fairies?

LUDLOW: [Reggie]

MYRA: Ah - he ain't much. Just a fella.

LUDLOW: He sent you a note. . . What does "anxiously awaiting your succulent dishes" mean?

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MYRA: You weren't supposed to read that, dammit! . . . Look, I'm sorry, Lud. You shouldn't read other people's stuff, that's all . . .

LUDLOW: *You said that already!!! (He throws his paints and paper.)*

MYRA: Lud. Pick that up. Now. *(He doesn't move.)* Now, Lud.

LUDLOW: Do you like him?

MYRA: *Now,* Lud. First the paints, then the answer . . . thank you . . . yes, he likes me . . . don't get that way. . . He wants to take me out. AAAh - hang on there - that's what the note, which you obviously scrutinized, is about . . . I make him a snack and he takes me to a flick . . . you following me so far?

LUDLOW: Loud and clear

MYRA: Don't give me that face.

LUDLOW: I'm not giving you my face. See? It's still here.

MYRA: . . . Lud, it's been such a long time since I've had a guy even look at me.

LUDLOW: I look at you.

MYRA: It's not the same thing

LUDLOW: They're all stupid.

MYRA: Well, *we* know that- but they don't.

LUDLOW: Reggie is a retarded name.

MYRA: Don't use that word! Let's give Reggie the retard the benefit of the doubt, okay? . . . Okay?

LUDLOW: Okay.

MYRA: How's Puck coming along?

LUDLOW: Okay . . . here. *(Gives it to her.)* You hate it.

MYRA: Naw, I always love them. It's great. It goes right on the 'fridge. *(She crosses to the fridge and pauses in front of it.)* Where did all the magnets go?

LUDLOW: I don't know.

MYRA: Lud-

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LUDLOW: I was trying an experiment.

MYRA: What kind of experiment? Lud, this isn't like the time you swallowed all them magnets and tried to stick that fork to your belly -

LUDLOW: *NO!* I've matured.

MYRA: Oh boy. What kind of experiment?

LUDLOW: To see if magnets stick to aluminum . . . num.

MYRA: What aluminum-num?

LUDLOW: *(Fidgeting.)* On the, on the window. *(MYRA crosses to the window and opens it. She leans out and looks, then ducks back in glaring at LUD. He continues sheepishly.)* I guess not.

MYRA: This is not funny - we're talking serious stuff here. I don't want any part of your body outside this window at anytime. Ever. You hear me?

LUDLOW: Loud - *(MYRA points a threatening finger at him.)* Yes.

MYRA: The last thing I need is to cancel my first date since Lincoln 'cause I'm too busy peeling my brother off the pavement with a spatula.

LUDLOW: Your point is made, Madam.

MYRA: It better be. *(She shuts the window and returns to the groceries.)*

LUDLOW: You wearing that for a date?

MYRA: *(Ignoring.)* Aw Lud, clean up your paints, okay? Jesus, I'm running late here. *(LUD collects his paints and puts them in a drawer.)*

LUDLOW: When's Rocky getting here?

MYRA: *Ricky!*

LUDLOW: Reggie.

MYRA: We . . . Listen Lud, I'm gonna pop a vessel here in a sec, just help me out, Okay?

UDLOW: Do what thou wilt swiftfooted time. *(Doorbell rings. Both freeze.)*

MYRA: *(Terrified)* Aw, Lud . . . could you . . . um. Hang on a minute, Ricky!!

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LUDLOW: Reggie.

MYRA: Aw Sh-Reggie! Be there in a minute! Lud, please, just let him in and tell him I'll be there in a sec. Can you do that for me?

LUDLOW: Of course, I *can* do it.

MYRA: *Will* you do it nice? Please? Please, Lud? Nothing funny - this is important.

LUDLOW: I won't converse with him.

MYRA: Does that mean yeah?

LUDLOW: Yeah.

MYRA: Thanks!! *(She kisses him on the forehead and sprints into the bedroom. LUDLOW goes to the kitchen window and opens it, then crosses to the door and proceeds to take off the lock. He then heads for the couch and sits. The bell rings again.)*

LUDLOW: *IT'S OPEN!!*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualfiier
Ohio State Qualifier

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